St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include relative clauses, inverted patterns and nominalisation. Proofread the paragraphs.

Technology has undoubtedly made our generation lazier. Not only we spend hours scrolling through social media, but we also order every meal through delivery apps, which means we never leave the house. Students, which live near school, still take the bus because walking seems too much effort. Rarely teenagers read a book when they can watch a video summary in five minutes. The important of exercising regularly is something that many of us have forgotten. Only by admitting the problem we can start to build healthier habits.

Technology has not made us lazier; it has simply changed the way we work. What critics fail to understand is that apps save us time for more valuable activities. Not only students can complete their homework faster with online tools, but they also use the time they save to learn new skills, that explains why so many teenagers now know how to edit videos. The belief that young people do nothing meaningful on their phones is wrong, because many of them, which run successful online businesses, started from nothing. The significant of these digital skills should not be ignored, as they prepare us for the modern workplace. Only when we accept that technology is a tool we can stop blaming it for our own lack of discipline.

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence breaks one idea into two parts so the most important information stands out. Study the patterns below.

Example 1: It-cleft – focusing on the cause

Plain:	People communicate less because they use messaging apps.
More formal:	It is messaging apps that make people communicate less.

Young people used to meet at the park after school, but now everyone sends messages from their bedrooms. A quick text is easier than a real conversation, so face-to-face friendships have become rare. It is messaging apps that make people communicate less, and this change will only grow deeper as technology advances.

Example 2: It-cleft – setting up a contrast

Plain:	Some people blame social media, but smartphones cause the real

	problem.
More formal:	While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem.

Every day there are news stories about the dangers of social media. While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem. Without a phone in their pocket, teenagers could not check their accounts every five minutes.

Example 3: Wh-cleft – presenting a recommendation

Plain:	Schools should teach students how to communicate face to face.
More formal:	What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face.

Many teachers complain that their students cannot hold a proper conversation. What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face. A single workshop on active listening would help teenagers rebuild the skills that messaging apps have quietly taken away.

Example 4: All-cleft – naming the only thing needed

Plain:	Teenagers only need one real conversation to remember the value of talking.
More formal:	All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking.

Parents often buy expensive devices or hire tutors to help their children socially. All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking. Once they experience the warmth of genuine human connection, the cold comfort of emojis will seem far less appealing.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence as a cleft sentence. The sentences are about technology and communication, so keep the register formal. Sets 1–4 are straightforward; sets 5–8 require you to change the part of speech.

Example Set 1 (It-cleft – the cause)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers send short messages because they are afraid of real conversations.
Prompt:	*Begin with ‘It is the fear of real conversations …’.*

Example Set 2 (Wh-cleft – what is needed)

Simple sentence:	Students need to practise face-to-face communication.
Prompt:	*Begin with ‘What students need to do …’.*

Example Set 3 (It-cleft – the contrast)

Simple sentence:	People blame social media, but modern phones are the real problem.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people blame social media …'.*

Example Set 4 (All-cleft – the only thing needed)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one proper conversation to understand the value of talking.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Example Set 5 (It-cleft – the cause, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People feel brave when they insult others online because they are anonymous.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the anonymity …'.*

Example Set 6 (It-cleft – the contrast, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People think technology is convenient, but it actually destroys our patience.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people think technology is convenient …'.*

Example Set 7 (Wh-cleft – the recommendation, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Schools should make students aware that talking face to face is important.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*

Example Set 8 (All-cleft – the only thing needed, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to be confident for one minute to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining the influence of artificial intelligence on students, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is … that … / What … is … / All … needs to do is …).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only … / Never … / Rarely …